



**Doncaster**  
Metropolitan Borough Council

# **Bessacarr**

# **Conservation Area**

## **Appraisal**



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# Bessacarr Conservation Area Appraisal

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## **Preface**

This interim supplementary planning document has been produced to provide guidance for planning applicants, planning agents, consultants, and others involved in the planning process. This document conforms with saved policies in the Doncaster Unitary Development Plan adopted in July 1998. This guidance will be re-issued as necessary as revised policy emerges through the Local Development Framework. This guidance will subsequently be subject to formal sustainability appraisal and will include a statement of community involvement with the intention of adoption as a Supplementary Planning Document in line with the local development scheme.

It is hoped that this guidance will cover most eventualities including all the main guidelines, which a prospective applicant should bear in mind when considering development proposals. Advice is available from the Environment and Planning Services Design and Conservation team and you are advised to make early contact before carrying out any work within the Conservation Area.

**The Planning Committee adopted this document, following six weeks public consultation, as an Interim Supplementary Planning Document on the 12 July 2005.**

## **1. Introduction**

Under the Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990, Local Authorities are required to formulate and publish proposals for the preservation and enhancement of Conservation Areas. Government guidance contained in Planning Policy Guidance Notes 1: “General Policy and Principles” and 15: “Planning and the Historic Environment” emphasises the need for the character and local distinctiveness of an area to be analysed and clearly defined in a written appraisal. This guidance is adopted by English Heritage and is laid out in their 1997 guidance note “Conservation Area Appraisals”.

This appraisal follows the English Heritage guidance and it aims to identify the special architectural, landscape and historical interest of the Bessacarr Conservation Area. This document will be adopted as Supplementary Planning Document (SPD) after public consultation. This appraisal will also provide the framework for a subsequent Development Control Guide and the possible service of an Article 4 Direction, which could reduce the amount of alterations to buildings carried out in the conservation area, without the need for planning permission.

## **2. Location**

This appraisal covers the Bessacarr Conservation Area, which is situated south of the Doncaster Racecourse and The Dome Leisure Centre and approximately three miles from the town centre.

The Bessacarr Conservation Area covers both sides of Bawtry Road, from its junction with Cantley Lane in the north, to the junction with Church Lane to the south (adjacent to Bolton Hill Playing Fields). The area includes the southwest side of Cantley Lane, St Wilfrid's Road, St Eric's Road, Whin Hill Road, and the junctions of Saxton Avenue, Ellers Road, Boswell Road, Middlefield Road, and Alston Road with Bawtry Road. Following the designation of the extension to the Conservation Area in July 2005, the properties on Eller's Road and Saxton Avenue are included.

### **3. Origins and development of the settlement.**

The area now called Bessacarr was once an area of rectangular fields, and small woodlands, which were enclosed in the mid 18<sup>th</sup> Century. This area was then known as Bessacarr Fields, comprising of “High Fields, Hawk Hills and Low Fields”. The topography of the area is characterised by a low rising ridge with land falling to the east and west, with the steepest slopes on the west. Bawtry Road runs along this ridge.

In the early part of the 19<sup>th</sup> Century John Jarratt acquired the area. The first houses of what became known as the Jarratt Estate were built in the late 19<sup>th</sup> Century. These houses are Hill Crest on Bawtry Road, which is still standing and Linton Dale on Cantley Lane, where the original house has been demolished and replaced by a more modern dwelling. This era was significant in the development of Doncaster, following the arrival of the railway industry. Both blue and white-collar housing was constructed expanding Doncaster in an easterly and southerly direction. By the 1920's the northern section of St Wilfrid's Road and St Eric's Road had been laid out and developed with substantial houses on broad plots, while Whin Hill was beginning to be developed. Development continued on both sides of Bawtry Road and extended past Whin Hill Road, whilst on Cantley Lane development extended to a similar position. Gradually the area was developed with a significant increase in the post war period, possibly due to the relaxation of building licences. The area hence experienced a long period of development.

#### 4. Prevailing and former uses and the influence on the plan form and building types.

The area is almost completely residential, except for Punch's Hotel, Private



Schools, care homes and a Veterinary Surgery on Bawtry Road. There are no listed buildings, shops or Public Houses in the Conservation Area. The Conservation Area contains a wide variety of private dwellings, in terms of size and architectural

detailing, from the castellated 'stone' houses on St Wilfrid's Road through elegant large brick and render Edwardian properties on Bawtry Road to modest bungalows. The unifying features of the Conservation Area, are its large ample plot sizes, long rear gardens with dwellings set back some ten metres from the road, well planted with trees and what can be termed a consistent building line. Very few properties come up to the roadside boundary. The low density of the dwellings is in contrast to the more modern development to the southeast, namely around Highbury Avenue and off Stoops Lane to the southwest. The plots narrow and the density increases further south towards Bawtry, still within the Conservation Area, from Rhodesia Court flats, but is still in character due to the long rear gardens.

It is this well treed spaciousness with dwellings in large plots, with an average plot density of 8



times the footprint of the dwelling that provides the character of the Bessacarr Conservation Area.



## **5. Archaeological significance and potential of the area.**

Bessacarr is now a large housing estate and has never been, as far as can be determined, an area of a medieval nucleated settlement. If one did exist it is most likely to have been near the junction of Stoops Lane and Bessacarr Lane (outside of the Conservation Area). Due to Bawtry Road being in the position of a Roman Road, there have been numerous finds from the Roman period, mainly coins and pottery.

There are no Ancient Monuments within the Conservation Area boundary. However, this should not be an indication of the lack of potential, especially with the previous roman finds.

## 6. Architectural and historic qualities of the buildings and their contribution

There are no listed buildings within the area but this does not lessen the contribution the buildings make, along with the trees and the public realm, for example the differing width of roads. Each of the main streets have a character of their own, which when combined provides the character of the conservation area. To describe the architectural qualities of the area, this chapter has been divided into each of the streets: Bawtry Road (including the junctions with the streets that are not all in the area), Cantley Lane, St Wilfrid's Road, St Eric's Road and Whin Hill Road. This is further enlarged by the streets that now form the extension to the Conservation Area, namely Eller's Road and Saxton Avenue.

### i) Bawtry Road

Bawtry Road provides the southern approach into the town and represents one of the most attractive routes into any large northern



centre. The combination of a broad highway with verges, extensive treescape and ample well spaced, largely two storey dwellings are one of the best visual features of Doncaster.

The north east side of

Bawtry Road is characterised by fairly substantial Edwardian dwellings of two storey in height, St Mary's School for example. These are the first houses to be built on Bawtry Road; the south west side is a slightly later development. Mainly of brick and render, some with projecting gables,



with slate or plain clay tiles roofs, sometimes steeply pitched, they tend to be well detailed with half-timber or decorative brickwork in the gables and red brick quoins in the rendered part. There are usually square bays and tall brick chimneys. After 85 Bawtry Road the dwellings become much closer together with narrower and tighter plots, moving closer to the road with a consistent building line, although retaining some of the detailing of the earlier dwellings.



However there are a number of houses dating from the 1950s that do not copy the previous details but are of significant architectural quality, dark brick with bands to break up the façade and wide mullioned bay windows.



The south west side of Bawtry Road contains houses of lesser architectural quality than their opposite neighbours but this does not lessen their contribution. Mainly of 1930s to 1960's the buildings tend to be of a darker brick, with brick detailing and plain tile roofs. One exception to this is 94 Bawtry Road, whilst smaller than the Edwardian properties the



details are copied. Unfortunately its rear garden has been developed by a block of 1970's style flats.

There are a number of boundary treatments throughout the Bawtry Road 'corridor', stone walls, brick walls, mixed species hedges and in minority, timber fencing.

ii) Cantley Lane.

For the purposes of the Bessacarr Conservation Area, Cantley Lane stretches from its junction with Bawtry Road to 92 Cantley Lane. The 1894 Ordnance Survey Map shows Cantley Lane undeveloped apart from where the property known as Linton Dale now stands. The road was tree lined, with plantations from the enclosure awards, and led to



Cantley Hall through to Blaxton to the southeast. The north side retains the majority of the plantations, fronting the land to Rose Hill Cemetery. It is the amount of trees that give this area its

character rather than the houses. There are a number of architectural styles, from very modest bungalows, to traditional 1950's houses with bay windows, some being



semi-detached, through to modern large executive houses with mock Tudor timber detailing in the gables. The majority of the houses are a smooth dark brick with slate or plain clay tiles; there are some clay pantiles but these are in the minority. The bungalows tend to be rendered. There are a number of tandem and backland developments, which tend not to be following the details of the more traditional buildings. St Bartholomew's Close is typical of this, large stone buildings with clay pantiled roofs, approached by a humped bridge from the side garden of 52 Cantley Lane. From 22 Cantley Lane towards Old Cantley, the footpath widens to allow for a wide grass verge between the footpath and the boundary of the dwellings. This and the fact that the dwellings are well set back from the road allows for extensive tree planting that is of great value. The front boundaries are of a mix, being either hedges or walls.

iii) St Wilfrid's Road

St Wilfrid's Road runs parallel to both Bawtry Road and Cantley Lane, sitting between the two.

The road is wide, with wide, particularly well maintained, grass verges between the property boundaries and the pavement. This allows for some street trees, which with those within the

gardens, due to the dwellings being set back into the front gardens, leads to an attractive 'treed' boulevard.





There is a great mix of houses throughout St Wilfrid's, from 1950's bungalows with steep roofs, Edwardian houses (the first house built on the road, being St Wilfrid's House), 1920s chalet style



(number 14), castellated 'stone' property (number 6), through to large modern executive houses. Originally the road was divided into substantial plots, in the region of just over 3,000m<sup>2</sup>, over the years

these gardens were sold for further dwellings, which infilled the gaps between the properties. However, there is still a sense of openness through the street scene.

The dwellings tend to be of red brick with a plain clay tile, there are



some examples of clay pantiles but these are rare. Numbers 7 and 11 have rendered first floors, number 7 has exposed red brick quoins and 11 has timber infill panels in the gable.



Number 14 St Wilfrid's Road is a chalet style dormer bungalow, with a commanding central dormer and two smaller ones above projecting bays below a steeply pitched tile roof. The walls are rendered and the

windows are small paned, which is typical of a 1920's bungalow. The building is considered to be a 'Key Building' in the Conservation Area.

iv) Whin Hill Road

Characterised by a narrow, gently curving road, which is bisected by St Wilfrid's Road. Again there are grass verges, which are well maintained, between the boundaries of the properties and the footpath.



The verges are fairly narrow when compared with those on St Wilfrid's or Cantley Lane. There is a mix of boundary treatments, with stone walls on the eastern side and hedges of various species. From the

junction of St Wilfrid's to Bawtry Road it is mainly walls and fencing.

Again the road is tree-lined which gives a very attractive appearance to the Conservation Area.





Again the properties are fairly substantial, mainly red brick with a plain clay tile roof; some also have rendered first floor panels. There are various details included in the design of the houses, including bay windows. Of interest are the individually designed bungalows, 7 and 9 Whin Hill, with course stone and monopitch roofs, set amongst trees. In terms of details contained in the dwellings, apart from bay windows (sometimes 2 storey), they are few and far between; small-paned windows and plain eaves treatments are in the main.

v) St Eric's Road



Again a mix of house types mainly rendered with a plain tile roof. The road is gently sweeping with grass verges, narrow, behind the footpath. The dwellings are well set back behind their boundaries, which are in

some cases open, but in the main protected by walls and hedgerows. The roofs are hipped in places and numbers 3 and 5 are worthy of mention due to their steeply pitched roofs, leaded window lights and roughcast render. Again the area is well treed and mention should be



made of the trees in the rear gardens of the properties, which contributes to the character of the area.



vi) Ellers Road



Ellers Road is characterised by being a narrow, linear road, which now runs into Stoops Lane (outside of the Conservation Area). Whilst being relatively narrow it is a bus route and a short cut from Church Lane lights onto Bawtry Road near to the

junction with Cantley Lane. During peak times this road can be very busy, which can be attributed to the nearby schools. As previously mentioned it the road layout is linear and straight in form with footpaths and a narrow grass verge before the boundary walls and hedgerows. The boundary walls, where applicable are below a metre in height and often have hedgerows behind them. The hedgerows varying in specie but are mainly conifers or Privet. Behind the boundaries are numerous trees but due to the relatively small front gardens, the majority of the trees are contained in the long rear gardens. Some of which back onto

the Lawn Tennis Club, which provides a prominent green space within this part of the Conservation Area.

This is also due to the slightly higher density of housing, when compared to St Eric's Road and Whin Hill. Whilst the plot sizes tend to be similar to these streets, the dwellings in Eller's Road tend to 'fill' the plots leaving little gap between the properties. Dwellings tend to be bungalows on the north side with detached houses to the south ranging from early to mid 20<sup>th</sup> Century style. The bungalows tend to be rendered, some with timber detailing in the gables, whilst the houses are mainly red brick although there is evidence of render panels. The roof material tends to be of slate although some have clay plain tiles and concrete pantiles although the latter material is rare.

vii) Saxton Avenue



In appearance the road seems to be slightly narrower than Eller's Road, although it shares the same straight, linear form. Again there are pavements in front of a narrow grass verge, which in turn is in front of low brick walls, or hedgerows,

which are a mix of species. There are numerous trees in the front gardens and in certain locations in the grass verges. Some of the tree's canopies have linked together to form an attractive green arch across the road.

Apart from two late 20<sup>th</sup> Century bungalows towards the junction with Bawtry Road, the houses are of mid 20<sup>th</sup> Century. Mainly semi detached houses on the northern side, with detached houses on the south. The buildings are of red brick with either slate or concrete roof

tiles. The houses have typical mid 20<sup>th</sup> century detailing for example two storey semi circular bays with tiles hung between the two floors. The front doors are often recessed behind stepped brick work and below concrete arches.

To summarise the whole of this chapter, the character of the area can be summed up as large executive houses, set back from their front boundaries, which in turn are set back from the pavements to allow for wide grass verges. The houses are not in the main well detailed but the ones that are, with their timber infill panels and rendered first floors add to the character and charm of the area as an attractive suburb of Doncaster.

## **7. Key unlisted buildings**

There are no listed buildings within the Conservation Area, however this is not to say that there are no key buildings that contribute to the area. A key building is defined as follows: -

- The work of a particular architect of local or regional note
- Has qualities of age, style and materials of a substantial number of buildings in the Conservation Area
- Serves as a reminder of the gradual development of the area or of an earlier phase of growth
- Has landmark qualities
- Reflects the traditional functional character or appearance of the Conservation Area
- Has significant historic associations with local people or past events

These key buildings are indicated on Map 2 of this appraisal. They range from the large Edwardian houses to the mid 20<sup>th</sup> century properties. It may be noted that some of these properties share the same detailing and prominence of their neighbours, which are not considered to be key buildings. This is due to inappropriate alterations, which have unfortunately reduced their importance.

Any omissions that may come to light are unintentional and do not imply that they are of no interest.

## **8. Character and relationships of the spaces in the area**

Open spaces, such as gardens, playing fields and the highways can contribute to a Conservation Area as much as the buildings. Trees and green spaces are dealt with in Chapter 11 of this document and are indicated on Map 2. The main character of the Bessacarr Conservation Area is the low density of the housing, which allows for a feeling of openness and spaciousness. This is in addition to the width of the highways, allowing wide grass verges that are well maintained. Bawtry Road, Cantley Lane and St Wilfred's Road are wide streets when compared to the gently curving Whin Hill Road and St Eric's Road, but each provide character to the Conservation Area. This street pattern and the low density of housing, significant gaps between houses and houses set behind front gardens, allows substantial views in and out of this Conservation Area, and are indicated on Map 2.

## 9. Traditional building materials and detailing

There is not one unifying material or detail within the Conservation Area, which to some extent gives character to the area. The main building materials tend to be dark bricks with a plain clay tile. However, there are numerous examples of half rendered buildings, rendered bungalows with steeply pitched roofs and chalet type dormer bungalows with sweeping tile roofs and rendered walls.

In terms of details there are numerous buildings with bay windows, some of



which project into the roof space or of two-storey height. When the first floor is rendered the Edwardian properties have exposed red brick quoins and in some cases timber detailing in the gables.

There are many types of windows, the Edwardian dwellings having smaller leaded lights, especially in the upper part of the window, some of which are stained. Large vertical sliding sashes and the 1950's style casement windows are steadily being replaced by UPVC double glazed sealed units, which are changing the character of the buildings. This is particularly true of the mid 1920s dwellings that are having their large Crittall metal bay windows replaced.



## 10. Green spaces and trees

As previously mentioned there are few green spaces, apart from Bolton Hill Playing Field on the very southern boundary of the Conservation Area and to some extent the many wide grass verges that make the roads within area attractive. Bolton Hill Playing Field is a protected open space in the Doncaster Unitary Development Plan and as such is protected from development of the area.



A significant part of the Conservation Area is the numerous trees and hedgerows, many of which are protected by Tree Preservation Orders. The trees in the front gardens of the dwellings add to the character of the streets and provide for the boulevard effect previously

mentioned. However, the contribution the trees within rear gardens make should not be discounted. Whilst it may not be appropriate to serve Tree Preservation Orders in certain locations, these trees are afforded some protection from removal. They make a significant contribution to the treescape of the area, providing height and colour, which is particularly visible from outside of the Conservation Area. The positions of the trees are indicated on Map 2 but this does not include all the trees or their accurate location. Any application for development that may affect these trees must be accompanied by an accurate tree survey.

## 11. Negative features

Negative features are described in the English Heritage guidance as elements that detract from the special character of the area. In terms of the Bessacarr Conservation Area, there are very few negative features. The relatively new, modern housing that has infilled the gaps between the original houses could be



viewed as being negative due to being inappropriate in design and detailing. The flats to the rear of 94 Bawtry Road, known as Boswell Court, are particularly intrusive and of a design that is out of keeping with the surrounding area.

The garage site adjacent to 10 Cantley Lane is of poor

quality and detracts from the surrounding area.

Some of properties have removed the front boundary hedgerows and replaced them with high brick walls with railings, which has had a significant effect on the character of a typical town suburb.

## **12. Neutral features**

Neutral features are described as areas that neither enhance nor detract from the character of the Conservation Area. The mid 20<sup>th</sup> century housing on the southern end of the Conservation Area can be viewed as a neutral area. The houses are of a relatively plain design, of their era, yet incorporate some of the features of the surrounding area. Their low-key appearance does not make a positive contribution to the Conservation Area but neither do they intrude. Punch's Hotel is a large block of a building with flat roofs and painted brickwork, which is set back off Bawtry Road. The front car park could be improved in terms of landscaping but again does not overly intrude into the Conservation Area. The flats within Rhodesia Court would have been considered to be a negative feature, but a new block of flats in a neo-Georgian style have been erected to the front, onto Bawtry Road. This new block does not copy the details of other properties in the Conservation Area but is screened by a significant row of trees, which lessens its intrusion in the streetscene. The modern housing estate of Convent Grove, to the north of Rhodesia Court, is well designed, but due to its high density is out of character with the surrounding area. However, due to the choice of materials and relatively good design, the properties do little to detract from the Conservation Area.

### **13. Action Points**

The following points will be considered by the Borough Council for the preservation and enhancement of the Conservation Area, subject to public consultation and funding.

- **The service of an Article four direction to prevent alterations that may alter the character of the Conservation Area. For example the need for planning permission to replace the roof coverings, windows and doors with modern materials.**
- **Proactively seeking agreement to plant hedgerows on the frontage of the buildings.**
- **Seeking agreement over the long-term maintenance and retention of the grass verges adjacent to the highway.**
- **The assessment of the tree cover in the area, to provide a management plan, which would include both, phased removal and new planting.**
- **The publication of a Policy Statement, which would include policies for the preservation and enhancement of the area, and give guidelines for new development.**

#### 14. Policies of the Unitary Development Plan

The full policies are contained in the UDP, which was adopted in July 1998. At the time of writing this document the aforementioned UDP is currently being reviewed.

- ENV 21 Protection of trees
- SENV 4 Conserving the built heritage
- ENV 25 Conservation Areas
- ENV 26 Demolition of buildings in Conservation Areas
- ENV 27 Enhancement of Conservation Areas
- ENV 28 Restoration schemes in Conservation Areas
- ENV 29 Designation and review of Conservation Areas
- ENV 30 Listed Buildings
- ENV 31 Repair and Restoration of Listed Buildings
- ENV 32 Additions and alterations to Listed Buildings
- ENV 33 Preservation and enhancement of Listed Buildings
- ENV 34 Setting of Listed Buildings
- ENV 35 Protection of the Boroughs Archaeological heritage
- ENV 36 Archaeological evaluation of sites
- ENV 37 Development affecting Archaeological sites
- ENV 38 Protection of sites from development
- SENV 6 Quality of design in new development
- ENV 52 Design of new dwellings
- ENV 53 Scale and appearance of new dwellings
- ENV 54 Alterations and extensions
- ENV 59 Protection of trees on development sites

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|----------|--------------------------------------------|
| PH 8     | Infill and small scale housing development |
| SPH 4    | Safeguarding residential land              |
| PH9-PH12 | Residential Policy Areas                   |
| PH13     | Promotion of high standards in design      |
| PH 14    | Residential and nursing homes              |
| PH 15    | Houses in multiple occupation              |
| SPH 5    | Priority Residential Policy Areas          |
| PH16&17  | Priority Residential Policy Areas          |
| SRL1     | Protection of existing outdoor play space  |
| RL1      | Open Space Policy Areas                    |
| T7       | Road Improvements.                         |